



BEFORE

After defeat at the Second Battle of Bull Run, morale in the Union ranks was low. It was partially restored by the reappointment of George McClellan as commander of the Army of the Potomac.

THE CONFEDERATE POSITION

Robert E. Lee's Maryland Campaign began well with the **capture of the Union arsenal at Harpers Ferry by General Stonewall Jackson** (see [Union stand](#)). But sooner or later he was going to have to face McClellan's **numerically superior Army of the Potomac**. The two forces met at Sharpsburg. Lee took up a **defensive position** overlooking Antietam Creek. With **scattered forces** still arriving, by nightfall on September 16 he had just 25,000 men. Lee gave command of the left of his line to **Jackson** and the right to **James Longstreet**, the two wings **meeting at Dunker Church**.

UNION STRATEGY

McClellan had some **75,000 troops** on the opposite side of Antietam Creek. On the evening of September 16, he started moving **Joseph Hooker's corps** across the creek to Lee's left. Initial skirmishes allowed the Confederates to **identify the direction of the main Union thrust** of the following morning.

At dawn on September 17, as Joseph Hooker's corps advanced up the Hagerstown Pike to slam into the left flank of General Robert E. Lee's army, the prospect for the Confederates was grim. Union troops advanced in daunting mass, well equipped and uniformed, in marked contrast to the ragged Rebels. There were no earthworks, so the soldiers fought in the open or were sheltered only by trees or terrain from the storm of artillery and infantry fire that erupted. Furious fighting raged in the Cornfield and the West Woods—locations lost and retaken time and again at an appalling cost in lives.

Battle for the West Woods

Brigadier General John Bell Hood's Texans, reportedly angered at having their breakfast interrupted, seized the West Woods back from the Union Iron Brigade at the expense of 64 percent casualties, with the 1st Texas Infantry Regiment sustaining losses of 82 percent. A Union division ordered forward by Major General Edwin Sumner counterattacked from the flank out of the West Woods, losing more than 2,000 men in half an hour.